

THE THAW

Spring is a subtraction.

The old almanac calls the start of it *risshun* — and then, a few five-day weeks on, *keichitsu*: "insects emerge from the ground." The image is exact. Spring is not an arrival of new things. It is the uncovering of what the winter held down — the first green made underground, now showing.

The instinct to honour at home is the same. The reflex of spring is to *add* — flowers, colour, the bright new cushion. The discipline of spring is to *take away*: to open the windows, lift the heavy layers, clear the surfaces the dark months let fill, and leave room for the light that is finally long enough to use.

The Swedes have the better word for it: *lagom* — not minimal, not maximal, but the exact, sufficient amount. And the Japanese have the principle the whole season turns on: *kanso*, simplicity — which, properly understood, is not about owning less but about removing whatever hides the essential. This issue is about the clear-out that reveals rather than the one that empties.

Open a window. Take one thing off every surface.
Begin there.

